

☒ RARE OR UNUSUAL RECORD☐ NEW STATE RECORD☒ ACCEPTED☐ REJECTED

2/17/76

Species: PURPLE FINCH

Carpodacus purpureus

(Vernacular Name)

(Scientific Name-use binomial)

Date(s): December 20, 1975 (see below) * Time Bird Seen: off & on all day to

Locality: 748 Eastdale Drive, Fort Collins, Colorado

Nearest Town:

County: Larimer County

Other observers who independently identified this bird:

NAME

ADDRESS

TELEPHONE

Ronald A. Ryder

748 Eastdale Drive, Ft. Collins, CO 80521

482-8089

Audrey T. Ryder

748 Eastdale Drive, Ft. Collins, CO 80521

482-8089

Optical Equipment: In hand (also with 7X50 Bushnell wide-angles & 20X B&L scope)

If photographed, type of equipment used: Exacta 35 mm with strobe light

Light Conditions: Have had them in excellent light and poor light

Distance from bird (how measured): In hand, banded and photographed (in 1975)

(#108-193025)

Number of Birds Seen: 1 on 12/20 Sex: ♀ ? Plumage: Female-like **

**According to Samson, F. B. 1974. Banding worksheet for Cassin's Finch. WBBA

Describe the bird's overall behavior and demeanor: Comes readily to feeder. I trap them in Potter Traps. Very similar in behavior to Cassin's Finches.

Describe in great detail the bird's size, overall shape, plumage and color-pattern. Include details on shape of bill, wings and tail. Give particular emphasis to the marks you used to identify the bird. Reference to its resemblance in field guide descriptions is not enough. Describe what you actually saw in the field: See photos.

As big as Cassin's Finches, with which it occurs at my feeders. Bigger than House Finch. Best distinguishing mark I've found is undertail coverts lack mid-line streaking that Cassin's Finches have. Verified this in hand with Blair, et al. "Vertebrates of the U.S." keys. Breast streaking appears much broader and eye-line more pronounced, with more obvious grayish-brownish patch behind eye in Purple Finch.

Since reporting the bird on Christmas Count I received Remen's article in C.F.O. journal and have been trying to recapture both Cassin's and Purple Finches that I have banded this winter to measure bills and wings.

*One or more Purple Finches have visited feeders this year (1976) Jan. 7, 8, 11, 12, 13, 19, 20, 21, 23, 26, 27, 28-31; Feb. 3-6, 9, 10, 13, 16, 18, 21, 26, 27, 28; Mar. 1, 2, 4-6 and today, March 7.

(OVER)

Describe the bird's song or call, if heard, including method of delivery, i.e., from perch, in flight, etc: No songs heard. Calls seem about same as Cassin's to me but am checking now that I have Remsen's paper. Chirp gently when in traps.

Describe the habitat in which you observed this bird:

At my feeders eating sunflower seeds.

How were similarly appearing species eliminated?

Mainly by more pronounced eye-line and lack of streaking in undertail coverts in Purple. Have trapped both Cassin's and Purples on same days to compare this streaking in hand.

Prior experience with this and similarly appearing species: Have observed, photographed, and had in hand both Cassin's (in Colorado) and Purples (in Newfoundland). In the past 20 years I have banded several hundred Cassin's and House Finches, mostly here in my yard but have only caught 4 Purple Finches here, and those in the past 2 years. Three different ♀-like birds banded in 1975, one each on 2/8, 2/15 and 4/20/75. One banded 1/11/76, probably one seen 12/20/75. No. 108-193025 was retrapped and photographed 2/16/75.

Books, illustrations and advice consulted and how did these influence this documentation? Peterson's Field Guides (Eastern and Western); Pough's Audubon Land Bird Guide; Robbins, et. al. Birds of North America; Bailey & Niedrach (paintings and descriptions). Also telephoned Bruce Webb one day when I had one in hand regarding undertail coverts.

This report was written from notes made during x after x observation; from memory x (All resorted to plus reference to photos I took)

PRINT NAME: Ronald A. Ryder SIGNATURE: R. A. Ryder DATE: 7 March 1976
Street Address: 748 Eastdale Dr., F Town and State: Ft. Collins, Colo. ZIP: 80521

Return to: JACK REDDALL - 4450 South Alton Street, Englewood, Colorado 80110

P.S.--I have debated collecting 1 of the 3 frequenting my yard this winter, but since I can trap, photograph and band them I see no need for a second specimen to be added to the Denver Museum. However, I am still trying to trap and photograph Cassin's and Purple /



56-76-24

Department of Fishery and Wildlife Biology

Colorado State University
Fort Collins, Colorado
80523

March 8, 1976

J. V. Remsen, Jr.
Department of Zoology
University of California
Berkeley, California 94720

Dear Van:

I read your recent article on "Identification of Purple and Cassin's Finches" in the C.F.O. Bulletin and find it most interesting but still can't always decide on whether some female-like birds I'm banding are Cassin's or Purples! I would like to send you two frozen female-like finches which I banded as Cassin's mainly because they had streaked undertail coverts and less pronounced white eye line stripes than similar birds I've banded which had unstreaked undertail coverts and which I've called Purples. (Both birds were collected 7 March 1976 although #108-19302 was initially banded 27 November 1975.)

However, the specimens by measurements when banded seemed to be too small for those you give for Cassin's, nor did the bill shape seem that which you illustrate for Cassin's. Would you please compare them with specimens there at the MVZ and let me know their true identity? I'll wait until I hear you're in Berkeley until I mail them.

Unfortunately I have no measurements for the 4 finches I banded in the last 2 winters that lacked streaking in the undertail coverts and which by facial markings I called Purple Finches. Needless to say, I will measure all of my Cassin's-Purples more carefully from now on.

Sincerely yours,

Ronald A. Ryder

cc: Jack Reddall ✓



Dear Jack,

Here's a copy of the letter I
sent to Ron Ryder. The data from
the specimens are:

RAR # 1066 - ♂ imm (no red) - Ft. Collins,
Larimer Co., Colo. 11-Dec-1976

RAR # 1064 - ♀ imm - 748 Eastdale Dr.,
Ft. Collins, — 7 Mar. 1977?

RAR ?# - ♀ imm 748 Eastdale Dr.,
Ft. Collins — 7 Mar. 1976?

(Originally banded 27 Nov. 1975 acc. to
Ryder)

This may be a very exciting year for
warm-water waterbirds in Calif. There have
been a few Blue-footed and Brown Boobies
around, including a Blue-f. off San Francisco.
Frigatebirds are everywhere. Craver's Murrelets
were numerous off Monterey. The Salton
Sea has had 3 Am. Oystercatchers, 1 White Ibis,
1 BB Tree Duck, and -10 R. Spoonbills. Vagrant

season is underway already with 2
Prairies, 1 Prothonotary and 1 Canada reported
so far. If you get a chance to make
it out here on any one of the fall
weekends, just let me know. I'm still
on crutches, but I'll be off them in a
week or so.

The ACU meetings in Berkeley went
very well. I won the prize for the
best student paper and so I was really
happy.

I heard a rumor that there was
an Aztec Thrush in Big Bend Natl. Park
about a week ago!

Have a good fall,

Van

September 1, 1977

Dr. Ronald A. Ryder
Department of Fishery and Wildlife Biology
Colorado State University
Fort Collins, Colorado 80523

Dear Dr. Ryder:

Sorry you didn't come to the AOU meetings. Sandy Williams left me 4 Carpodacus to identify, and I have just finished comparing them with our series here at MVZ.

The specimen labeled Cassin's Finch is definitely a Cassin's. Wing length, culmen length, bill shape, fineness of breast streakings, distinctness of streakings on crown and back, and presence of streaks on undertail covert, are typical for cassinii. The cheek patch seems abnormally strong and well defined.

The other three specimens are definitely Purple Finches. The streaks on the undertail coverts are unusual, but I have seen several specimens with streaked undertail coverts. A key to Carpodacus which arrived today from BBL indicates that Purples may have streaked undertail coverts. Otherwise, the three specimens are typical in culmen, length, bill shape, wing measurements, broadness of breast streaking, darkness of back and crown, and distinctness of cheek patch.

As for subspecies, californicus can be ruled out on the basis of wing length (too long for californicus) and back color (too heavily streaked with white and not tinged with olive).

This leaves two subspecies, C. p. purpureus, the race most likely in Colorado, or C. p. nesophilus, a poorly differentiated race from Newfoundland. Lacking specimens of this latter race, I can't rule it out definitely but to label your birds C. p. purpureus would be safe.

I hope this has been of some help. Thanks for the opportunity to look at your specimens. We'll be shipping the specimens back to you within a few days.

Sincerely,

Van Remsen